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Blog

Odd Bedfellows: Tea Partiers and Solar Panels

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What may be the most unusual pairing in recent memory, the staunchly conservative Tea Party movement has taken the mantle of promoting clean energy. Long considered (<http://wapo.st/19fkW95>) a waste of resources by conservatives in the US, solar power is now embraced by those who identify as staunchly fiscal conservative in the Republican Party.

Greentech Media recently sat down with Debbie Dooley, founder of the Green Tea Coalition and Conservatives for Energy Freedom. She discussed how solar panels are a fit for the tea party message of expanding personal freedoms.

"I simply look at this as we're Americans coming together for a common purpose and a common goal," Dooley tells The Energy Gang podcast (<http://bit.ly/1MwM6Nd>). She goes on to explain the wide variety of groups that have decided to put differences aside and promote clean energy.

Environmental groups and Christian coalitions in Florida and Indiana have come together to support solar. This is big news considering both Florida and Indiana are staunchly conservative states. They are often cold to the idea of bipartisan initiatives, especially when it comes to the environment. This news is so shocking that some have even come to call this new partnership an unholy alliance.

Unholy Alliance

"I can tell you the term unholy alliance did not really originate with us. It originated with a lobbyist with Georgia Power," Dooley says. "We were advocating for more solar and she got up and spoke at a breakfast and she said that [the] Tea Party had formed an unholy alliance with Sierra Club, and they did not quite know what to do about it."

Bipartisan support for solar generated energy is virgin territory and an unlikely common ground for conservatives and liberals. However, it makes sense considering tea party members have often based their stance on the fight for personal freedoms.

Julia Watson, a Florida resident who attended an event held by Debbie Dooley's Conservatives for Energy Freedom, exclaimed disbelief at the restrictive channels homeowners have to protest unjust laws. "I can't believe (the utilities) are allowed to influence the governor and the legislature to the degree that they do," she told (<http://bit.ly/1E9rILK>) Tampa Bay Times.

Scott McIntyre, president of the Florida Alliance for Renewable Energy and CEO of Solar Energy Management agrees with the groundswell movement. He told (<http://bit.ly/1xOasvk>) Planetsave.com, "It is time to bring Florida out of the solar dark ages."

Takeaway

It is comforting to see bipartisan support on such an important issue. Energy sustainability and cutting emissions should be at the top of everyone's mind. We are at a turning point on this planet and it will take the continued support of those in politics who may be diametrically opposed on other issues to come together for this greater cause.

The future may be bright, especially for the south eastern states in the US. Debbie Dooley and others are leading the charge to put politics behind them and approach energy independence for homeowner and planet alike. "I simply look at this as we're Americans coming together for a common purpose and a common goal. And we put differences aside," Dooley concludes.

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